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Dear Mr. Ghodsi,

It's a genuine honor to reach out to you, especially through Mrs. Jane Sun, to whom I'm grateful for the care she has shown me. As you once said, "people don't want to leave their home country, but sometimes staying becomes untenable, and they eventually have to flee."

At age 18, I was facing the death penalty after my parents outed me as gay, which is criminalized in Tunisia. While I was homeless and a fugitive, I worked as a server and cleaned bathrooms to afford library access. I used that access to teach myself English so I could write my college applications and submit them through public library computers, which earned me admission to Columbia University. I escaped to the United States as an international student with only the clothes on my back, and in a month, I will graduate from Columbia University with a Bachelor's degree in Computer Science.

You have spoken candidly about fleeing the Iranian revolution, and I deeply relate, especially because I lived through the Tunisian revolution that sparked the Arab Spring. Your perseverance, not only surviving what you were forced to flee, but thriving in the field you pursued, and ultimately chasing the American dream by democratizing data and AI, has been a profound source of inspiration to me. Along that same thread of opportunity, at the Columbia University AI Laboratory, I was able to lead the development of gAyI, an AI tool for LGBTQ mental health support, with published outcomes that reflect what you champion about democratizing data and AI, and that technology should widen access responsibly and reach

people at every level. In my case, it was a way of democratizing support for people who cannot safely ask for help.

With years of experience, including research and internships at YC funded companies, I'm ready to devote my life to Databricks' mission and to building systems that are worthy of the trust people place in them. However, at this moment, my biggest barrier isn't ambition or readiness. It's my immigration status and the need for H1B sponsorship. I'm unable to renew my Tunisian passport due to my persecution in Tunisia, and asylum cases in the USA are currently frozen indefinitely. Therefore, my last hope remains to stay in the USA, as my departure would forfeit my right to return.

If given an opportunity at Databricks, I will honor it with the same perseverance that carried me from surviving on the streets of Tunisia to graduating from Columbia University in New York.

Thank you for being an inspiration to refugees around the world and a powerful leader for software engineers.

With utmost respect and gratitude,

Sammy Nawaly Abdella